

# BIOGRAPHY OF BASO CHOKYI GYALTSSEN

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## Birth and Early Life

His Holiness Trichen Baso Chokyi Gyaltsen —The First Kundeling Tatsak Jedrung, Hotoktu Nomun Han —was born in 1402 as the younger brother of Khedrup Je. He was a direct disciple of Je Tsongkhapa and the fifth in the lineage of the Seven Jamyang Tsangpa Masters.

From a very young age, he entered the path of the Buddha’s precious teachings. Studying at the feet of Je Tsongkhapa and his foremost disciples, he attained exceptional mastery of the Buddha’s teachings and their commentaries.

## The Ear-Whispered Lineage

From Lord Manjushri, the complete instructions of the extremely secret Ear-Whispered Lineage along with Great Emanated Scripture, a method for swiftly attaining Buddhahood through the profound path of Guru Yoga within a single lifetime, even in this degenerate age—were transmitted to the great Je Tsongkhapa.

Je Rinpoche then passed on the Ear-Whispered Pith Instructions and Great Emanated Scripture to Tokden Jamphel Gyatso, and entrusted the instructions to Khedrup Je.

## Master of the Gaden Ear-Whispered Lineage

In accordance with the prophecy given by Lord Manjushri to Tokden Jamphel Gyatso, the “Emanated Scripture” of the teaching lineage, together with its instructions, was transmitted solely to Je Baso Chokyi Gyaltsen. This transmission was sealed as a strictly one-to-one lineage, preserving its utmost secrecy.

Khedrup Je likewise entrusted the Ear-Whispered instructions exclusively to Baso Chokyi Gyaltsen, making him the sole holder of these secret teachings.

As prophesied by Manjushri, Baso Chokyi Gyaltsen later bestowed the “Great Emanated Scripture” and the instructions of the Geden Whispered Lineage as a “hidden teaching” to his disciple, Drupchen Chö Dorje.

## Transmission of the Lineage

Drupchen Chö Dorje transmitted these teachings to Gyalwa Ensapa Lobsang Dhondup, who in turn passed them to Khedrup Sangye Yeshe. From him, they were handed down to Panchen Lobsang Chokyi Gyaltsen.

Recognizing that such unsurpassed instructions must not decline, Panchen Lobsang Chokyi Gyaltsen composed the *Lama Chopa: Union of Bliss and Emptiness*, drawing on their essential meaning. He also composed the root text and commentary on the Geden Mahamudra.

In addition, the profound instructions of the Chöd path—transmitted from Lord Manjushri to Je Tsongkhapa and then to Tokden Jamphel Gyatso—were fully entrusted by Tokden Pa to Baso Chokyi Gyaltsen. In this way, Je Baso became a key figure in the lineage of the Gaden Ear-Whispered and Chöd teachings, as well as the Stages of the Path to Enlightenment (Lamrim) and other traditions.

## Reknown and Spiritual Realisation

Through deep and unwavering practice at Baso in Tsang, he attained profound realizations of bliss and emptiness, and was thereafter widely known as Baso Choje.

## Ascension to the Gaden Golden Throne

Later, when the Fifth Gaden Tripa, Je Lodrö Chokyon, wished to enter retreat, he invited Gyalwa Gendun Drup to assume the Gaden Golden Throne. However, Gendun Drup declined, saying: “Invite Baso Chokyi Gyaltsen, the younger brother of Khedrup Chöje, to the Gaden Golden Throne. His scholarship and realization are unsurpassed, and the radiance of his enlightened activities pervades everywhere.”

When Je Baso resolved to devote himself single-pointedly to the practice based on the Pith-instructions of the Ear-Whispered Lineage, a prophecy arose from Je Tsongkhapa and Vajrayoginī, declaring that if he were to ascend the Ganden Golden Throne, it would greatly benefit the teachings.

Urged insistently by Choje Lodro Chokyon, and in accordance with the wishes of Gyalwa Gendun Drup and others, he accepted the invitation to take the Ganden Throne.

He was then invited to Tashi Lhunpo, where Gyalwa Gendun Drup said:

“Now that you are going to the seat of Je Tsongkhapa, when I offer prostrations to you, please do not return the prostration.”

With these words, the omniscient Gendun Drup, together with his retinue, offered prostrations to him.

In 1463, he ascended the Ganden Golden Throne.

### **Activities as Gaden Tripa**

For eleven years, he upheld the throne, conferring countless teachings and ordinations upon innumerable disciples.

In particular, he gave extensive and far-reaching teachings on *Lamrim* (the Stages of the Path to Enlightenment) and became renowned as Panchen Chokyi Gyalpo—the Great Scholar, the King of Dharma.

On one occasion, Dolma Bum, who was pregnant with Jetsun Chökyi Gyaltsen—the future author of the Sera Je monastic textbooks—came to meet him. At that time, he established a special auspicious connection, saying:

“The son you are about to bear will become a great holder of the teachings and bring immense benefit to the Dharma. Name him Chokyi Gyaltsen. As soon as he is born, clothe him in this garment.” With these words, he offered her an auspicious ceremonial scarf.

### **Passing and Relics**

In 1473, amid many wondrous signs, he demonstrated the manner of passing into parinirvana. When his body was cremated, numerous images of Arya Lokeshvara, sacred syllables, and relics emerged from his remains.

### **Writings**

His writings include Generation and Completion Stages of Kalachakra, as well as profound instructions on the view of the Middle Way in both extensive and concise forms.

### **Principal Disciples**

His disciples included the “Three Vajra Brothers,” who attained the State of Union in a single lifetime, as well as Kunga Deleg of Nenyang; Gyuchen Kunga Dhondup, the founder of Gyuto Tantric Monastery; Ganden Tripa Darton Lobsang Dragpa; Drepung Tripa Jamyang Galo; Sera Tripa Nyalton Paljor Lhundrup; Tashi Lhunpo Tripa Panchen Yeshe Tsemo; Phagpa Lha; and many other exalted masters.

### **Legacy of Successive Incarnations**

In his successive incarnations, two served—on separate occasions—as the peerless Regents of Tibet. Without recourse to the Golden Urn, they recognized and enthroned both the Ninth and Thirteenth Dalai Lamas.

Across different incarnations, they also served as tutors to the Eleventh and Thirteenth Dalai Lamas, as Chief Lama to the emperor of China and the king of Mongolia, and as the first abbot of Yonghegong in Beijing.

In this way, they carried out vast enlightened activities for the benefit of the teachings and sentient beings across Tibet, China, and Mongolia.